

South Block **BLUES**

The shadow of Sharm el-Sheikh, growing turbulence in the neighbourhood and calls to reform the foreign service mean the new foreign secretary may have a bumpy ride

By Saurabh Shukla

In the first floor corner room of South Block, which is the foreign secretary's office, the teakwood panelling has been freshly polished and the scroll on the wall has a new name: Nirupama Menon Rao. As the elegant diplomat comes to terms with a 24x7 routine, she is faced with a cocktail of problems that will test India's diplomatic prowess. Pakistan's flip-flop on the 26/11 probe makes its commitment to fight terror suspect, while non-proliferation ayatollahs in the US are preparing the ground for a comprehensive test ban treaty and China's aggressive posture is causing worry back home.

An accomplished jazz singer and author and an avid I-pod buff, Rao seems to realise that as the head of the foreign service with over 150 foreign missions and posts, she has to micro-manage India's diplomatic outreach. "Improving ties in the neighbourhood will be priority; we also need to focus on public diplomacy and environment diplomacy," she says, realising that without dousing the fire in the neighbourhood, India can't hope to fulfil its global power aspirations. Her appointment comes at a critical time when India's relations with Pakistan are going through testing times in the wake of the 26/11 attacks and her predecessor Shiv Shankar Menon being blamed for the mis-step at Sharm el-Sheikh. The Balochistan reference is likely to be advantageous to Pakistan as it could put India on the mat every time Delhi raises its con-

RAO OUTSIDE HER
SOUTH BLOCK OFFICE

REUTERS



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